

THE BEST OPEN SOURCE APPLICATIONS FOR DAILY USE



What the proprietary world can do, FOSS can do better! That's what this article hints at, as it takes you through the 11 most used open source apps.

Every day, we use a variety of applications without even wondering about their origins. Our main goal is to complete the task at hand, which could be as mundane as watching a movie clip, or doing something more complex such as editing an image. As long as these needs are satisfied, we remain loyal to particular software. But users need change over a period of time, so application developers work hard to offer the best set of features within a short time. Also, these applications then have to survive in the intensely competitive market. On one hand is a multinational company investing millions of dollars in designing a commercial application, and on the other is a bunch of highly motivated people working together to design an open source application. There's often the misconception that open source applications are not as good as their commercial counterparts—but this isn't true.

Open source applications can be even better than their commercial variants in some cases. These often begin with an individual who designs the first version and uploads it on the Net for others to test and use. As word spreads, more people from the open source community start taking part in the project—testing, reporting bugs, or even solving them. Over time, the application's features keep improving. Here is my list of the top open source applications that are used daily. My choices are debatable. Many distributions have these packages available in the software manager (or via a PPA added in the Ubuntu Software Centre), but if not, installing them is quite simple. Usually, all it takes is double-clicking the downloaded file. Hence, I haven't covered this aspect in detail.

VLC media player

Over the years, I have switched from one media player to another, in search of certain features. This stopped when I stumbled across VLC. It could play almost all file formats I threw at it, and even played broken files, repairing them to some extent. The interface is clean and simple. It hardly crashes. You can add subtitles for your favourite movies and even change the video aspect ratio to fit your screen. I highly recommend it for all users who love to watch movies, and it's even great for playing songs. Get it from <http://www.videolan.org/vlc/>.

Mozilla Firefox

Used by millions around the world, it's simple, elegant and quite stable. The 'Private Browsing' feature makes the browser forget history, searches, user accounts, etc, for that session—quite useful for those who value their privacy or who are using public computers. Firefox has many useful add-ons for routine tasks. The very large Mozilla community conducts various activities like launch parties, adopting animals, etc. FOSS enthusiasts can join it, or even become campus representatives. Get the Fox from: <http://www.mozilla.org/en-US/firefox/channel/>.

Pidgin

I have accounts at GMail, Facebook, Yahoo, MSN, etc. It gets very difficult to continuously switch between windows when I log in to all simultaneously and people start chatting with me. Well, Pidgin is the single-window